soon led to an effective bisection of Berlin into an eastern Soviet-controlled zone and a western zone controlled by the rest of the Allies.

In June 1948, with the Cold War becoming acute, the Soviets blocked the railway and highway transportation corridors leading from the western parts of Germany to Berlin, thereby blockading the western part of the city. They wanted to force the Americans and their allies out of West Berlin, leaving the eastern part of Germany under total Soviet control. The agreements signed in conjunction with the Potsdam Conference established three air corridors for flights to West Berlin and back. The Americans took advantage of that provision to break the blockade from the air. The US Air Force performed something of a miracle for the two and a quarter million people of West Berlin, flying in thirteen-thousand tons of food supplies daily and conducting more than two hundred thousand sorties over a twelve-month period.

The Soviets eventually gave up and lifted the land blockade in May 1949. In the same month the Western allies ended the occupation of their part of the country, declaring the creation of the Federal Republic of Germany. The Soviets followed suit in October, announcing the creation of the German Democratic Republic in their sphere of occupation. Sovereign rights were restored to the two German governments with the exception of Berlin, which remained under four-power occupation. The main problem that the Soviets faced, given the continuing Western presence in Berlin, was not military, political, or even ideological but economic. The United States offered the Marshall Plan, a $17 billion revitalization package, to war-ravaged Western Europe, resulting in an economic miracle in West Germany. As the Soviets lacked resources to revive the economy of mainly agricultural East Germany, West Berlin soon became an attraction to East Germans and an escape route for those who wanted to leave the socialist "paradise" for the capitalist "inferno" in the West.[10]

The burgeoning crisis over Berlin played an important role in Khrushchev's rise to supreme power in the USSR. In June 1953, a workers' strike in East Berlin grew into a popular uprising against the regime of the East German communist strongman Walter Ulbricht, only to be crushed by Soviet tanks. At the same time, Khrushchev executed his coup in the Kremlin by arresting Lavrentii Beria, thereby making himself first among